

sion gathering from decision making

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Paralysis by analysis is something all companies should seek to avoid. In managing through this at an all-remote company, leaders should ensure that all colleagues understand that consensus doesn't scale.

Thus, there should be no goal to achieve consensus. This may feel awkward or unnatural to those coming from colocated corporate environments, but trusting decision makers and living out the value of iteration prevents unnecessary slowdowns in your organization.

By intentionally separating the process of decision gathering and decision making, you provide ample opportunity for everyone to add input, offering up fresh angles for consideration that may well sway the mind of the DRI (directly responsible individual).

It is vital for all-remote companies to foster an atmosphere of trust and learning, such that grudges are not held against decision makers after decision gathering has occurred. At GitLab, this is manifested in our Collaboration value, which includes kindness, sharing, short toes, no ego, and assuming positive intent.

Applying iteration to everything

Iteration is oft applied to engineering, but asking only part of the company to iterate can create discord. All-remote companies must empower every member of the team, across every function and job level, to approach their work with an iterative mindset.

By applying iteration to everything, it removes the barrier of fear and judgement. It also enables faster cycles, and it makes miscues far less damaging.

For example, don't write a large plan, only write the first step. Trust that you'll know better how to proceed after something is released. Iteration can be uncomfortable, even painful. If you're doing iteration correctly, it should be.

Instilling this in an all-remote team is difficult. Most people are naturally inclined to only showcase polished work. In turn, managing this aspect of an all-remote team requires reminders that it's preferred to share unfinished work.

Leaders should work diligently to ensure that teams have a low level of shame and believe that everything is in draft and subject to change.

Learn more about GitLab's value of iteration in our Handbook, and read how one team used survey results to iterate on culture.

Company-wide organizational chart

There are no corner offices in an all-remote company. Although you should consider the organizational structure that makes the most sense for you (and iterate as the company evolves), one thing that should not change is the level of transparency.

To give each member of the company an equal view of how the organization is structured, how job levels/families are established, and what reporting structures look like, it's wise to consider an org chart accessible to all team members.

This removes ambiguity and enables clearer lines of communication.

We invite other all-remote companies to mirror GitLab's approach to publishing its team structure.

Avoiding dotted lines and matrix organization

{{< youtube "tSp5se9BudA" >}}

In the video above, published on GitLab's YouTube channel, GitLab co-founder Sid Sijbrandij and Arch Systems CEO Andrew Scheuermann discuss structure within distributed companies.

In all-remote companies, it is easy to fall into a situation where you work with a day-to-day lead but report to someone else. There are no physical office structures to reinforce reporting structures.

Leaders in an all-remote company must work to avoid dotted lines and matrix organization. Everyone should report to exactly one person, and that person should understand your day-to-day tasks and be well-positioned to assist you in removing obstacles to thriving in your role.

Whenever there is need to work on a specific, high-level, cross functional business problem, a working group should be established for that need.

Learn more about GitLab's approach in the Leadership section of our Handbook.

Focusing on results

{{< youtube "6QC1OwoddD8" >}}

In the video above, published to GitLab's YouTube channel, members of the engineering team demonstrate a focus on metrics.

Perhaps the easiest way to avoid overanalyzing management in an all-remote company is to focus on results. Focusing on results over hours worked creates an atmosphere where colleagues direct effort on the right things · shipping great code, making a client happy, solving a teammate's problem, etc.

This enables team members to complete their work and turn their attention to non-work activities (family, exercise, reading, caregiving, philanthropy, etc.) as quickly as possible.

By focusing on results, each team member has less of a mental burden to carry. They're aware that results are what matter as opposed to items like personal success, status, and ego.

Learn more on GitLab's Results value in our Handbook.

Objectives and Key Results (OKRs)

All-remote companies should go beyond striving for results. They should add as much detail and clarity as possible to what those results are, and what is measured along the way.

This can be achieved by implementing Objectives and Key Results (OKRs), a widely used framework for setting strategy and removing ambiguity over what matters.

Learn more about GitLab's implementation of OKRs.

Key Performance Indicators (KPIs)

Managing results requires clear communication of what's being measured. KPIs strip away guesswork and allow global teams to look at uniform data for making decisions.

It's vital that all-remote companies make KPIs available to all. This not only helps each team member focus their efforts on driving results that move needles that matter, but it creates empathy.

Although KPIs are emotionless, allowing teams to understand what other teams are working towards creates an atmosphere of compassion, and enables team members to more easily offer help that is specific to an indicator.

Learn more about KPIs at GitLab.

Encourage flexibility and balance

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In a conversation with GitLab's Head of Remote about company values, community contributor JD Lewin suggested that much of what leaders concern themselves with (surrounding management) can be addressed by creating a respectful work atmosphere.

When considering a new employer, he noticed that many conversations focused on the work rather than the environment. His articulation of this was powerful, and is transcribed with permission below.

> It's not about what the work is. I ask this: "Does the organization support and complement what the rest of my life consists of? Does going to work each day snap into what the rest of my life is?"

>

> For example: being a dad in the early 21st century means you need to show up in your child's life. I need to know that I can step away from my work in the middle of the afternoon if that's what my family requires of me. The culture must support that. In turn, I'll want to work the rest of my life for an employer who creates such an atmosphere.

>

> Waking up and wanting to work each day is a function of the relationship between the people at a company.

Getting started: the early days of remote management

Leaders should ensure that new remote hires read a getting started guide, and make themselves available to answer questions throughout one's journey with the company.

Tomasz Tunguz describes it as such in an article entitled "The early discipline of remote startups."

> As teams scale, they need to develop infrastructure to successfully manage and coordinate large numbers of people. But in the early days, by virtue of being close to each other physically, it's easier to delay some of these investments.

>

> A quick hallway meeting of a few key stakeholders might be all it takes to commit to a strategic change. A last-minute all hands roused through word-of-mouth may be the prelude to a fundraising announcement.

>

> For a business that exists somewhere on the distributed-to-remote continuum these options don't exist, or at least they are significantly harder. These kind of communications are just as necessary within remote or distributed teams, but they require more planning, more foresight in order to be successful.

>

> Some very early stage companies are bringing in these disciplines from the outset, because of the demands of remote work. And this is a wonderful thing, because this investment will compound over the life of the business. - Tomasz Tunguz, venture capitalist at Redpoint Ventures

GitLab Knowledge Assessment: All-remote management

Anyone can test their knowledge on all-remote management by completing the knowledge assessment. Earn at least an 80% or higher on the assessment to receive a passing score. Once the quiz has been passed, you will receive an email acknowledging the completion from GitLab. We are in the process of designing a GitLab Remote Certification and completion of the assessment will be one requirement in obtaining the certification. If you have questions, please reach out to our Learning & Development team at learning@gitlab.com.

{{% include "includes/isthisadviceanygoodremote.md" %}}

Contribute your lessons

GitLab believes that all-remote is the future of work, and remote companies have a shared responsibility to show the way for other organizations who are embracing it. If you or your company has an experience that would benefit the greater world, consider creating a merge request and adding a contribution to this page.

[Return to the main all-remote page.](#)

SECTION: company/culture/all-remote/meetings.md

How to run an effective meeting at GitLab

We're thoughtful about how we run meetings, because, when done right, they are forums to increase efficiency, enhance collaboration, and drive results. The guidelines below are intended to help you run a great meeting at GitLab!

What to do before the meeting

1. Ask yourself if the meeting is necessary. Though we have a bias toward asynchronous communication, a strategic balance between synchronous and asynchronous communication is required to achieve maximum efficiency. Moving a project or discussion forward asynchronously when feasible is preferred if it can be done efficiently and achieve desired results. Before scheduling a meeting, ask yourself if asynchronous methods could be effectively used to achieve the desired outcome.
1. Review participants time zones. Though we have a bias toward asynchronous communication, when a meeting is determined to be necessary review all participants' time zones. Consider creating meetings that overlap between EMEA/APAC + APAC/AMER + AMER/EMEA.
1. Ensure meeting DRI. When creating meeting across time zones, nominate volunteers to host and facilitate those meetings in their working hours that align better with their time zones.
1. Send the meeting invite with proper advance notice. A meeting with team members will usually traverse multiple time zones. We recommend you send meeting invites 72 hours (minimum 24 hours) in advance of the meeting to give people time to respond to the invite. In addition, consider who is required in the meeting and mark non-essential participants as optional.
1. Include a link to an agenda document in the invite. Team members should be able to get context before the meeting through reviewing agendas, supporting materials, etc. Meeting agendas should be shared 72 hours (minimum 24 hours) in advance of the meeting. Team members will need to know what is being discussed to decide if their participation is needed or whether their meeting attendance is optional.
1. Provide slides and supporting videos in advance. We embrace Neurodiversity by adopting a variety of different work styles and communication styles. Providing multiple ways to consume information (written / video / audio) allows everyone to contribute independent of their preferred comprehension style.
1. Use "speedy meetings." This Google Calendar setting creates meetings of 25 / 50 minute duration, which leaves time to write notes, stretch, etc. in between meetings.
1. Use the Zoom scheduler plug-in to add video conferencing to your Google Calendar event. Leveraging the Zoom plug-in automatically adds Zoom links to your event, and reduces the probability of user error in copying and pasting an incorrect video conferencing link.
1. Check your audio quality. Research shows that when the audio quality is high, people judge the content as better and more important. We recommend you invest in equipment to generate the highest-fidelity audio in your remote work setting, such as using a microphone.

What to do during the meeting

1. Start on time. It's important to begin and end meetings on time in order to minimize disruption.
1. Recording. For group meetings where there are multiple time zones, consider recording the meeting to allow for async participation.
1. Give audio and video feedback. If you are unable to see or hear someone, let them know so they can address and correct.
1. Name pronunciation. Inline with our values, consider these tips to ensure name pronunciation

during the meeting:

1. Ask all participants what is your preferred name or do you have a nickname? Example: "My name is pronounced .you can call me ."

1. Introduce yourself, and mention your pronouns and pronunciation, and ask participants if they want to introduce themselves. Reminder that pronouns can be set in applications we use for collaborating

1. Adding team members name pronunciation in agenda.

1. If you are unsure, it is always okay to ask for a reminder on how to pronounce a team member's name.

1. If your name is mispronounced, one can always say: "Thank you for attempting to pronounce my name, it's actually pronounced {name}."

1. Ensure your Slack profile name pronunciation has been completed.

1. Consider adding a link to the pronunciation of your name to the agenda doc in the attendee section.

1. Ensure your Google profile name pronunciation has been completed.

1. Avoid presenting in most meetings. Valuable synchronous time should not be used to present in most cases. Instead, recorded presentations make content accessible, prevent confusion, and increase participation for team members that prefer consuming content asynchronously. It is OK to present spontaneously to share unplanned material during a meeting, but stop sharing once the point is made. This ensures that the video stream is preserved for team members to engage and interact with each other.

1. Be intentional about introductions (or not). Some meetings may benefit from introductions, so be intentional about either doing introductions or not. If you are going to do introductions, make sure participants are aware beforehand so they are prepared. Create a list of people with their roles, and use that for guiding the introduction sequence. Let each individual introduce themselves so that Zoom emphasizes the speaker's video stream.

1. Provide verbal cues. If you're going through an agenda document, then add context: "bullet 3c, Sam, you added that point, can you verbalize it for us?" Similarly use slide numbers when going through a presentation to ensure that all attendees are tracking on the content.

1. Adhere to the agenda order to ensure inclusiveness. People may add agenda topics to the agenda asynchronously and synchronously during the meeting. In guiding discussions, ensure that agenda topics discussed are equitable and fair - don't let a single person or subset of the group monopolize the agenda at the expense of others.

1. Document in real-time. Since not all team members will be able to attend a meeting live, documentation is a vital part of avoiding team dysfunction. Follow Live Doc meeting best practices to increase cohesion, discipline, and transparency.

1. End on time.

What to do after the meeting

1. Capture action items from notes. For an ongoing meeting series, GitLab has established nomenclature such as adding tags like "TODO" and "DONE" to track action items. You can also file issues in GitLab.com to track action items.

1. Consider important decisions. When the meeting takes place outside of some participants' time zones, consider confirming decisions and actions for 24-48 hours. This will allow participants to contribute asynchronously.

1. Upload recording. When the meeting is recorded, add the recording link and password in the agenda with in 12 hours after the meeting to allow for async consumption for people in different time zones. Also consider uploading to YouTube if it can be done so consistent with SAFE guidelines.

1. Assess and Iterate. Once the meeting concludes, reflect on what worked, what didn't work, and what you need to do differently to run a more effective meeting. This process touches three of our CREDIT values: Iteration, Efficiency, and Results for Customers. By taking a small amount of time after a meeting to focus on continuous improvement, we can apply those improvements in future meetings. This drive for continuous improvement drives Efficiency, which is the foundation for Results.

What is a remote meeting?

A remote meeting, also known as a virtual meeting, happens when people use video and audio to connect online.

10 ways to do all-remote meetings right

"How do you do meetings right?" is a common question asked of all-remote companies like GitLab. The following guide assumes you've already questioned whether the meeting should happen in the first place; if you haven't, start with GitLab's guide to asynchronous workflows and communication.

Much of the same advice for running a good in-person meeting applies to remote meetings, with a few notable distinctions.

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{{% card footer="If you have to have a meeting, at least make it fun!" %}}

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1. Make meeting attendance optional

When you work in a global all-remote company, the usual assumptions about availability are opposite the norm. We have a growing team working in over 65 countries, with many time zones covered, which makes synchronous meetings impractical, burdensome, and inefficient. Anyone who has worked in a corporate environment has likely seen the sarcastic "I Survived Another Meeting That Should Have Been An Email" award. As an all-remote company, we do not look to a meeting by default; when they are necessary, we strive to make in-person attendance optional by enabling asynchronous contribution.

In many companies, synchronous meetings are used as a mechanism to create consensus. As you'll read in the Leadership portion of GitLab's handbook, we are not a democratic or consensus driven company. People are encouraged to give their comments and opinions, but in the end one person decides the matter after they have listened to all the feedback.

This works because of our values, which leads GitLab to hire individuals who enjoy being a manager of one, a point detailed in our Efficiency value. Team members are empowered to decide whether a sync meeting is the best use of their time, and set boundaries when needed.

Record meetings to encourage async participation

You should aim to record all meetings. This allows team members to catch up on what transpired

and adds context to notes that were taken during the meeting. Learn more about recording in Zoom in the Tips and Tricks section of GitLab's Handbook.

Managing meeting attendance for team members

At the same time, even GitLab team members may find themselves on one of two extremes.

1. Some folks may find themselves with too many meetings on their calendars. Conference rooms have attendee caps. Virtual meeting rooms can hold more than a stadium worth of people, so there are no physical constraints around the number of folks who can be invited to a meeting. Help over scheduled folks by proactively marking them as optional if they are not required. This helps them in their prioritization and time management. Also revisit meetings for which you are the DRI after each meeting. Can folks be removed from a meeting or meeting series? Or, can then be moved from required to optional? Avoid stale meeting invite lists.

1. Some folks may find themselves with few meetings, so they aren't particularly selective in their attendance. A topical meeting may be an opportunity to connect with team members or feel a sense of belonging, but a participant should choose not to attend a meeting if this is the primary reason for attendance. There are alternatives for informal communication that can better address this need.

Managers can support their direct reports by reviewing the directs' calendars with them on a regular basis to align on which meetings should have in-person attendance.

2. Cancel unnecessary meetings

Meetings should not happen if there isn't a clear objective and adequate preparation. In most cases, meetings that should be postponed are cancelled before they begin. At GitLab, roughly 1% of meetings should end within the first minute as it becomes clear that the meeting doesn't have a known meeting outcome, key material required for a productive conversation, or adequate participant preparation. Cancelling a meeting quickly at the start of it is not a failure. It takes leadership to quickly read the situation and make an efficient and time saving call.

Recurring meetings are often established as meaningful points along a given journey. Don't hesitate to cancel them after their purpose has been served. Cancelling meetings isn't an insult to those on the invite list. In fact, ridding multiple calendars of an unneeded meeting is liberating to everyone involved. At the end of each meeting, the meeting DRI should evaluate whether the meeting can be cancelled or the meeting cadence or duration can be reduced. If there are multiple folks who may have an opinion, this can be an agenda item for discussion at the end of the meeting.

3. Start on time, end on time

A nontrivial amount of time is required to regain focus after a distraction. While it is not always possible to schedule meetings such that they do not create distractions, it's important to begin and end meetings on time in order to minimize disruption.

When scheduling a meeting at GitLab, we value people's time and prefer the "speedy meetings" setting in our Google Calendar. This gives us meetings of, for example, 25 or 50 minutes - leaving some time to write notes, stretch, etc. before continuing to our next call. Learn more in the Communication section of GitLab's Handbook.

4. All meetings must have an agenda

"No agenda, no attenda." Every work-related meeting should have a single live doc agenda affixed to the calendar invite at the time that the invite is added to calendars.

Meeting agendas should include:

1. A relevant meeting title
1. Attendees with titles and organization names, if not in the same company
1. Background Information or context. This should answer:
 - What do folks need to know or review in order to meaningfully participate in the meeting or meeting sequence?
 - Why is this group gathering? The meeting's desired outcome should be clear.
1. The date (if multiple meetings on a topic, you can use the same agenda document, but put dates as H1s or H2s in Google Docs for easier navigation)
1. Questions or details. A place in the agenda where participants can add thoughts either synchronously or asynchronously.
1. If the meeting was recorded, after the meeting, update the agenda document with a link to the recording.

Meeting DRIs should prep the agenda at least 72 hours before the meeting. This helps participants to:

1. Can make informed decisions around whether they should prioritize synchronous participation.
1. Have adequate time for any required review.
1. Have adequate time to contribute asynchronously within the agenda.

We've created a templated example that you can copy and use in your organization. There is additional guidance and a separate template for 1:1 meetings. Coffee chats do not require agenda as their function is informal communication.

While it is problematic to have no agenda, it is also problematic to have more than one agenda. Meeting and meeting notes require a single source of truth. If you are in a meeting with more than one agenda, stop the meeting as soon as this is known. Clarify the agenda to use with other attendees and immediately deprecate the additional agenda. Add a link to the agenda being used from the deprecated agenda, so anyone who discovers it is aware of the source of truth agenda.

5. Document everything live (yes, everything)

If you determine that a meeting is needed to move a project forward, address a blocker, or resolve a miscommunication, visit our detailed guide on conducting a live doc meeting.

It's not rude to focus on documentation in a meeting. A surefire way to waste time in a meeting is to avoid writing anything down. Meetings within an all-remote company require documentation to be worthwhile. Here are some additional ways you might document a meeting (in addition to the live doc agenda):

1. During the meeting, add input and feedback from attendees to existing agenda items.
1. When referencing a team member's name in the meeting agenda, ensure that both the first and

last names are displayed. (e.g: When we write the name of the person who is speaking in the agenda, we should write the first and last name or use the tagging feature as a prefix)

1. For action items, we go directly to a GitLab issue or merge request. This creates a direct takeaway from the meeting, where ideas are summarized and action can begin immediately. Be sure to add a link the issue or MR in your meeting agenda for reference and completeness.

1. For optional attendees, or key team members who could not attend the meeting live, tagging them in the resulting GitLab issue(s) enables them to get themselves up to speed and contribute when it is suitable for their schedule.

1. Record the meeting. You can always delete an unwanted meeting, but you cannot turn back the clock and record a meeting retroactively. This is particularly important if you want to present or wish to have a written transcription of the meeting. Zoom's Cloud Recording supports transcription natively, and Otter is another popular transcription tool.

6. Use the right tools

All-remote meetings are made simpler given that there's no jockeying for space in a conference room, scrounging for huddle rooms, or wondering if a given group still needs the room they've reserved - all very real conundrums in colocated environments.

1. GitLab uses Zoom for video calls and screen sharing. Its simple recording function makes it easy to capture meetings for others to watch at a later time. Learn more about how we optimize Zoom usage in our meetings in the Tools and Tips portion of our Handbook.

1. We use GitLab Issues to document action items that come out of any given meeting, and loop anyone else in who opted out of real-time attendance.

1. Leverage tools such as Calendly, which can show you as busy in chat tools like Slack.

Use GitLab to replace meetings

A major enabler for reducing the quantity of meetings necessary at GitLab is our own product. GitLab is a collaboration tool designed to help people work better together whether they are in the same location or spread across multiple time zones. Originally, GitLab let software developers collaborate on writing code and packaging it up into software applications. Today, GitLab has a wide range of capabilities used by people around the globe in all kinds of companies and roles.

You can learn more at GitLab's remote team solutions page.

7. Avoid hybrid calls

A hybrid call is one that has a mix of participants in the same physical room, together with others who are remote. Hybrid calls should be avoided, as it's better to have everyone on a level playing field for communication and discussion.

If a hybrid call must happen, however, everyone should use their own equipment (camera, headset, screen) even if they are physically sitting in the same room. This ensures that everyone is on the same playing field in terms of call experience. If possible, it's best to separate briefly for the call and find your own workspace, creating a 100% remote call. This helps avoid audio problems from delays and feedback. Learn more about why hybrid (partially remote) calls are horrible in the Communication section of GitLab's Handbook.

8. Meetings are about the work, not the background

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In the above video interview between GitLab co-founder Sid Sijbrandij and NoHQ's Dominic Monn, the two discuss common challenges and solutions to building, sustaining, and scaling a thriving remote workplace.

They speak at length about meetings within a remote environment. In particular, Sid shares that remote workers should embrace the benefit of being free to take meetings with loved ones nearby.

> Enjoy the benefits of your kids barging in on a meeting. That's the best distraction in the world. - GitLab co-founder Sid Sijbrandij

Your appearance, surroundings, and background can be the source of great stress and anxiety when preparing for a video call. At GitLab, we encourage team members to bring their whole selves to work.

1. Don't waste time trying to find the perfect backdrop for your video call.
1. Celebrate unique surroundings. It's not uncommon to see GitLab team members participate in a video call from the shores of a lake, coffee shops, RVs, or even while walking.
1. Focus on your internet connection and your audio quality (use headphones/), reducing listening fatigue for others.
1. Encourage family and housemates to say hello! All-remote employees invite others into their homes via video call, creating a unique opportunity to share their lives with colleagues.
1. Consider not using a video call. Visit GitLab's Communication section of the Handbook to learn more.

9. It's OK to look away

Many organizations have attempted to improve the utility of meetings · usually as a workaround to actually doing less of them · by implementing a "screen-free" meeting mandate. At GitLab, we empower team members to be the manager of their attention.

1. It's completely acceptable to work on other tasks if (a particular portion of) a meeting doesn't apply to you. If your meeting is with only GitLab team members please leave your camera on to allow people to see the overall interest level and adjust the time spent on certain topics. If your meeting includes non-GitLab team members consider turning off your camera because people outside GitLab might not know that it is acceptable for us to work on other tasks during a meeting.
1. It's not embarrassing to ask occasionally for something to be repeated. Because you manage your own attention, you are free to engage with other work and then be pulled back into a relevant part of the meeting conversation.

1. It feels rude in video calls to interrupt people. This is because the latency causes you to talk over the speaker for longer than during an in-person meeting. We should not be discouraged by this, the questions and context provided by interruptions are valuable. This is a situation where we have to do something counter-intuitive to make all-remote meetings work. In GitLab, everyone is encouraged to interrupt the speaker in a video call to ask a question or offer context. We want everyone to contribute instead of a monologue. Just like in-person meetings be cognizant of when, who, and how you interrupt. For example, this can help avoid the issue of men too often interrupting women.

Learn more in the Communication section of GitLab's Handbook

10. Say thanks and be creative

At GitLab, we have a dedicated Slack channel devoted to saying thanks. Kindness is embedded in our Collaboration value, and gratitude is an essential part of our culture. This reinforces what connects us as a geographically diverse team.

A great example of several GitLab's values being used to generate a creative outcome from a regularly scheduled meeting is detailed on the company blog: "How we turned a dull weekly all-hands into a podcast"

While we can thank team members within meetings, we do not thank each other for meeting participation as this is not part of our values and could reward folks attending meetings that they are not required in. This would not support efficiency, a GitLab value.

Remote meeting FAQ's

What are the benefits of a remote meeting?

Scheduling a virtual meeting allows you to set the meeting length and invite a limited number of people. You can participate in a remote meeting from almost anywhere in the world! If you are working in your garage or basement, be sure to use a green screen behind you and put up a professional background image to present well on screen.

What are the challenges of a remote meeting?

You are not expected to be available all the time, but there may be times you will need to flex your schedule to schedule or attend a meeting with someone from another time zone outside of your typical working hours. Most remote-meeting challenges fall under two categories:

1. trouble with technology
1. communication complications

Both can be overcome by checking your internet connection regularly and growing aware of the communication preferences of others.

How can I prepare for a remote meeting?

1. Review your calendar at least a day in advance of the meeting, so that you are aware of the meeting and what is being discussed. Meetings should not be surprises. When people know what is

on their calendars and are aware of related materials, they can make smart decisions around how much time to spend reviewing materials in advance.

1. Prepare for your meeting by carefully reading the live doc agenda attached to the calendar invite before the meeting. Here's an example of what one might look like.

1. Check and make sure your technology, Internet, and environment are good.

1. Don't be afraid to ask for help if you need it in order to be fully prepared.

What should I do after a remote meeting?

1. Write everything down so you can retain and recall important details.

1. Schedule action items, next steps, or a future meeting. Input into the proper directory (Google Drive, Salesforce, etc.) to help ensure there are no balls dropped.

1. If you missed something, re-watch the video recording.

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How can I improve my remote meeting skills?

Lorraine Lee has created training on how to better your video and presentation skills for an all-remote workspace.

Key points include:

1. How to effectively use lighting, visuals, and curate your environment

1. Using movement, power words, and the think/do/feel matrix to keep your audience engaged

1. Smiling, making eye contact, and framing yourself in video

1. Elevating energy by standing up, projecting, and using hand gestures

What are "All-remote Virtual 'Offsites'"?

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When working in an all-remote company, there is a strong tendency to avoid traditional "offsites" that require travel from all participants. GitLab has experimented with all-remote "offsites" as a method to provide some of the deeper shared understanding that results from such meetings without the heavy financial, personal, and environmental toll of travel. These longer, structured meetings have had mixed results. Here's what we've learned so far:

1. Block off everyone's calendar just as if they'd traveled for an offsite. Remove all other distractions (Slack, email, etc.) and enable Do Not Disturb modes on phones and computers.

1. Ensure you have a strong desired outcome before planning a virtual offsite. This will ideally be discussed before the date and time are set, and written into the agenda.

1. Coordinate pre-reading and work that can be done asynchronously ahead of the remote offsite.

1. For newly formed groups, include initial ice-breakers and activities to develop shared trust. For example, begin with a show & tell that allows team members to showcase something they've assembled or have contributed to.

1. Schedule breaks during calls longer than 1 hour.

1. Keep in mind the downsides of time-zone shifting to attend these synchronous meetings. Team

members in shifted time-zones may arrive with lower energy.

1. Combine asynchronous activities between synchronous meetings.

1. Take more time than you normally would to explain activities and intent, framing your position with additional context. In traditional offsites, understanding comes from observing others in the room, and this can be more difficult remotely. If you are leading the offsite, encourage people to have short toes and assume positive intent when it comes to being interrupted, as a higher-than-expected amount of back-and-forth may be necessary to achieve understanding.

1. If possible, spend a full day working together with breaks, and share a remote meal together coffee-chat style.

1. Check your tools to make sure they can support the synchronous setup you are proposing.

All-remote virtual offsites are cost-effective and enable team members to pivot back to life outside of work as soon as the meeting concludes. However, there is still great value in in-person interactions, and leaders should aim to include those opportunities when possible rather than shifting entirely to remote offsites.

How do I run a remote board meeting?

In April 2019, GitLab transitioned our board meetings to all-remote. This means that none of the attendees are colocated. By doing so, we've made it as easy as possible for the right people to attend our board meetings, including board members, observers, executives, and anyone doing a deep dive, which can include directors, managers, and, in some cases, individual contributors.

Learn more on how to run an all-remote board meeting.

What is the difference between remote and in-person meetings?

When asked during an INSEAD case study interview about an all-remote company's ability to bring people together in the same physical space for a meeting, GitLab co-founder Sid Sijbrandij provided the following reply.

For context, Sid joined the Zoom call from San Francisco, while the researchers joined from Singapore.

> We can [bring people together in the same physical space], but we don't do it because it's very inefficient. Imagine the cost of this meeting if I had to fly to your location, or you to mine.

>

> [Colocated companies] fall back on extremely inefficient things, like flying people halfway around the world for a four-hour meeting. GitLab doesn't fall into that trap.

>

> We have meetings that are more efficient. I bet our meetings, via Zoom, are more efficient than meetings in a conference room. With live note-taking, up-front agendas, and our follow-up, GitLab meetings are more efficient.

>

> Not only do we have more efficient meetings, we also do not have the time waste of flying people across the world.

>

> I see multinational organizations where you're supposed to be in the office even if you're the only person in that location, just so they can check that you're working. That is a ridiculous waste of time.

>

> So, no, colocated companies do not have an advantage. They don't have the benefit of knowing how to do remote right because it's not in their DNA.

>

> Of course there are benefits to colocated meetings · it's easier to interrupt each other, it's easier to see what everyone around the room is thinking, you don't have wireless issues, it's easier to look each other in the eyes, it's easier to break bread before/after the meeting, it's easier to talk a walk or do something fun together.

>

> We try to take advantage of them, though. We have GitLab Contribute where we all come together to go on excursions and have informal chats. As an executive group, we come together every quarter for 2.5 days for high-velocity meetings. Those are augmented with Google Docs, and we allow people to attend remotely if they cannot join in person.

>

> There are benefits, but they aren't as big as people make them out to be.

>

> The biggest thing is taking the initiative to interrupt each other, as that's harder in a remote setting. At GitLab, we solve that by making sure that questions are in a Google Doc in advance so it's clear who has a question and who to hand the conversation off to. · GitLab co-founder Sid Sijbrandij

Who should be invited to meetings?

We can use our DRI framework to inform who should participate in a meeting. The DRIs and consulted folks will play key roles within meetings. A meeting DRI or facilitator owns the meeting. Other DRIs may own specific activities in support of an initiative. Consulted people are those whose opinions are sought, typically subject-matter experts; and with whom there is two-way communication. Most informed people should not be invited if there is a more efficient way to engage or cascade information. When informed folks are invited due to needs for immediate alignment or limitations around effectively cascading asynchronously, they should not be added as a recurring participant in a sequence of meetings.

How do you enable folks who don't attend meetings in-person to effectively participate?

When agendas are shared at least 72 hours in advance, you can have efficient asynchronous participation. If sticking to the agenda becomes the norm, folks who have thoughts or questions, but choose to prioritize other things above meeting attendance, can have confidence that their thoughts will be considered and their questions will be addressed. Team members can later review recordings and notes. This helps to minimize team members' fear of missing out on key details.

How do you create a low meeting culture?

In addition to making it effective and efficient for participants to contribute asynchronously, don't thank people for showing up in meetings. At GitLab results and efficiency are values, participation is not.

How do you keep participants engaged in a remote meeting?

1. Have your video on at all times because it's much more engaging for participants.
1. Use team members' names to make everyone feel welcome and recognized.
1. Advise participants to mute their mics to minimize background noise and ensure all attendees hear the speaker.
1. Don't be discouraged by interruptions. Sometimes, there is a lag on a remote call.
1. Speak up as soon as you notice something is not working.
1. Start and end your calls on time.
1. Give attendees the option to ask someone else to please verbalize for them if they aren't comfortable speaking up.

For more tips, visit the [GitLab video call communication guide](#).

What are the best alternatives to Zoom for remote meetings?

While GitLab uses Zoom as the primary video platform for communications, others may prefer different tools. Some popular Zoom alternatives are:

- WebEx
- MS Teams
- Skype

GitLab Knowledge Assessment: All-Remote Meetings

Complete all knowledge assessments in the Remote Work Foundation certification to receive the Remote Foundations Badge in GitLab Learn. If you have questions, please reach out to our Learning & Development team at learning@gitlab.com.

[Return to the main all-remote page.](#)

SECTION: company/culture/all-remote/mental-health.md

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What are the signs of remote work burnout?

Remote work burnout can manifest itself in many ways, including stress, isolation, or anxiety. Leaders need to promote a healthy, non-judgemental culture where individuals are encouraged to prevent or work through burnout rather than hiding or internalizing struggles.

In this CEO handbook learning session, Sid and other leaders at GitLab discuss the importance recognizing the signs of remote work burnout, taking time off, and addressing imposter syndrome.

{{< youtube "odKdZqc69k" >}}

How can you prevent remote work burnout?

It can be more difficult to notice burnout on a distributed team. Managers and individual contributors should be trained and prepared to understand the signs - and more importantly, the entire team should be trained in behaviors and processes that help prevent it from happening in the first place.

Do not celebrate working long hours

{{< youtube "fH8nmtEoBh4?start=1579" >}}

In the People Group Conversation above, GitLab's Sid Sijbrandij responds to a discussion on the topic of burnout and overwork.

> There's individual freedom, and there's peer pressure. As a company, we should take a lot of care that there's no peer pressure to work long hours.

>

> Everyone is used to that [being pressured]. At every company I've been at, that was a celebrated thing. We have to be super, super careful that we do not celebrate that at GitLab. ·
Sid Sijbrandij, GitLab co-founder

There's a fine line between thanking someone publicly for going above and beyond to help out in a situation, and sending a message that work should always trump life.

Burnout rarely happens all at once. Rather, it typically takes one by surprise, eventually coming to a head after days, weeks, or months of overwork creep.

While working one additional hour to move a given project forward is likely not debilitating when viewed in a vacuum, it can trigger a revised baseline where you must continue to overwork in order to maintain the new status quo.

This becomes toxic when managers fail to recognize that a given sprint should not reset the baseline of what is achievable on an ongoing, sustained basis. It becomes disastrous when team members do not feel safe bringing this up to their managers in a 1:1 setting.

Particularly in a company where results are valued above all, managers should be careful to not assume that results garnered in a given period of overwork are the new norm. This places team members in an unfair scenario where they feel pressured to perpetually overwork in order to meet expectations. More broadly, as other team members witness this, they will be less likely to go above and beyond in special cases for fear of trapping themselves in a similar cycle of overworking just to meet ever-increasing (and unsustainable) expectations.

Rest and time off are productive

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Though it sounds counter to conventional wisdom, clarity comes through time away from work. Just as a human must inhale and exhale to survive, one cannot expect to remain healthy and productive if only inhaling more work.

As John Fitch describes in the book *Time Off*, there are four stages of creativity. This was initially outlined by English social psychologist and London School of Economics co-founder Graham Wallas.

1. Preparation
1. Incubation
1. Illumination
1. Verification

John Fitch, co-founder of *Time Off*, articulates this on *The Culture Factor* podcast. A portion of the interview is transcribed below.

> Incubation and illumination are only activated through time off · by not doing the actual work, by doing something else. While you're resting, parts of you are still working. I came to this contrarian belief that your best work is actually cultivated outside of work.

>

> 50% of the creative process requires you to not be working. · John Fitch

Establishing a culture that gives voice to this reality is critical in removing the stigma from taking breaks and prioritizing well-being. Rest isn't at the expense of work; it's a core function of doing excellent work.

As part of his session at REMOTE by GitLab, John shares how organizations can intentionally build company policy and culture that support and encourage time off. Watch the session:

{{< youtube "bQMof7oSh2o" >}}

GitLab's L&D team also hosted a live speaker series with John to discuss how intentional time off can help manage burnout and enable team members to create high quality work. Check out the recording:

{{< youtube "BDvpouM-us" >}}

Wendy Barnes, Chief People Officer at GitLab, sat down with Samantha Lee from the Learning and Development team for a short conversation to answer the following questions.

1. What strategies can team members use to manage burnout?
1. How can managers support their team members in taking time off?
1. How can managers help prevent burnout?

Watch the short interview below.

{{< youtube "oN8IzhQmFf4" >}}

Your rest ethic is as important as your work ethic

Traditionally, we've emphasized the importance of having a strong work ethic. Finding a balance with your work ethic and your rest ethic is essential for avoiding burnout. Building and nurturing your rest ethic creates the energy needed to enable your work ethic. Dr. Sandra Dalton Smith talks about the importance of rest and the types of rest we need in her TedTalk,

The 7 Types of Rest that Every Person Needs.

Examples of how you might define your rest ethic:

1. Commitment to taking time off every month, and truly unplugging from your laptop or work projects when you're off
1. Using a non-linear workday to take a long break mid-day to walk, exercise, read, or work on a passion project
1. Practice a morning routine to help prepare you for the workday
1. Practice an evening routine to turn off work and be present with your friends, family, or time alone

Start building a rest ethic now with this 8-minute meditation hosted by Britt Turpack. You can watch the full speaker series event with Britt on the GitLab Unfiltered YouTube channel.

To learn more about building a rest ethic, refer to this course by John Fitch and TimeOff entitled Design your Rest Ethic.

GitLab hosted John Fitch for 2 Live Speaker Series during the month of May 2021. In the following discussions, John shared great strategies for manager enablement of rest ethic, the importance of rest, and the impact that intentional rest has on results. Check out both recorded sessions below!

Session 1

{{< youtube "uklTuJeiTDo" >}}

Session 2

{{< youtube "acVRU5UjJEo?start=04" >}}

What are the benefits of remote work for mental health?

There are many mental health benefits to remote work, but some that top the list are:

1. Increased flexibility in your daily life (for kids, parents, friends, groceries, sports, deliveries).
1. Less time and stress, and money wasted on a commute (subway and bus fees, gas, car maintenance, tolls, etc.).
1. Reduced interruption stress and increased productivity.
1. Less exposure to germs from sick coworkers.
1. You can choose your working hours based on when you're most productive.

What are the challenges of remote work for mental health?

Remote work is not for everyone. We have done a deep dive on specific remote-work challenges and solutions, including mental health struggles that could be aggravated by:

- the onboarding process
- loneliness

- communication breakdowns
- work/life balance
- time management

What are some tips for managing mental health when working remotely?

A remote role can feel lonely, especially if you're transitioning from a traditional office setting. It's important to take inventory of your mental health and take action as needed.

Document processes around mental health

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Burnout, isolation, and anxiety are issues that impact team members across all companies, regardless of their organizational structure. While they aren't always intertwined, there is significant interplay between them.

In a colocated setting, it's entirely possible for a team member to appear well, but struggle with these issues internally. That said, it tends to be easier for those in an office to reach out to a team member they trust (or their people department) if burnout, isolation, or anxiety is impacting their ability to thrive in the workplace.

In a remote setting, where in-person interactions are less common, it's easier to fall victim to isolation. This is particularly true for those who are not well acclimated to remote work, or have just started their first remote role.

Because you are likely to work alone most times, it's more difficult to remember that you do have colleagues to call on - especially if you're already overwhelmed, burned out, or suffering from anxiety/depression.

Create clarity through documentation

The aforementioned reality makes it all the more important for any company hiring remote workers to place a great deal of focus on documenting processes for team members who face these difficulties. Along with offering professional assistance (see GitLab Modern Health as an example), be sure to showcase documented resources of where to turn during onboarding, and reinforce this in ongoing learning and development sessions.

Remote team members may feel less comfortable reaching out to a person when experiencing mental duress, so it's vital to ensure that answers and resources are easily discoverable within a company's handbook.

Leverage documentation to ease anxiety

This approach enables managers and leaders to experience less anxiety and worry of being a single point of failure. By documenting diligently, it is easier for managers to take time for themselves, prioritize family, and earnestly disconnect during holidays and vacation.

Documentation allows a significant portion of one's managerial expertise to be tapped into even

while the manager is away recharging, and this intentional decentralization creates a greater sense of calm for both leaders and direct reports.

John Fitch, co-author of *Time Off* and the Chief Product Officer at Voltage Control, shares a powerful anecdote on this approach on *The Culture Factor* podcast. A portion of the interview is transcribed below.

- > My function of head of design and prototyping · if I'm the only one doing it, that's a problem. If I go away or something happens to me, that entire function is compromised. It's a single point of failure. When you decentralize, you get rid of single points of failure.
- >
- > Clarity is a part of a decentralized organization. That way, anyone can pick up and understand "It's clear what we're here to do. Our values are clear."
- >
- > Much like an engineer will take their code and document it, that work is important. Another engineer can look at their code, and without emailing that person, make use of what has been created. Quality documentation has historically been a hallmark of engineering. We treat that the same regardless of function. When I'm away, I can be away. I don't have to worry about my team forgetting things.
- >
- > Just as journaling is important externally, it's powerful internally. Documenting my functions opens my eyes to self-improvement. As I'm writing things down, I can more clearly see better ways to do things. · John Fitch

Force work into async tools

Working entirely or primarily in a chat tool such as Microsoft Teams or Slack is a pathway to burnout. Humans were not designed to have hundreds or thousands of people demanding things from them with red bubbles. There is a reason your phone can only allow one conversation at a time.

Leadership can create a more humane atmosphere by leaning on a tool (or tools) that enable asynchronous workflows, thereby reducing meetings and creating more time for focused, deep work. GitLab uses GitLab to accomplish this.

GitLab is a collaboration tool designed to help people work better together, whether they are in the same location or spread across multiple time zones. Originally, GitLab let software developers collaborate on writing code and packaging it up into software applications. Today, GitLab has a wide range of capabilities used by people around the globe in all kinds of companies and roles.

You can learn more at [GitLab's remote team solutions page](#).

Create a non-judgemental culture

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Transparency is a core value at GitLab, and should be a value at any organization employing remote team members. Leaders should assume that some team members will feel uncomfortable surfacing issues involving isolation, burnout, and anxiety at work. This can stem from prior

experiences, where bringing such issues to light could lead to negative consequences.

To combat this and de-stigmatize such issues, leadership should work to build and sustain a non-judgemental culture. This starts by celebrating a diverse team, and creating an inclusive work environment.

At GitLab, we encourage team members to include overall feedback on how their life is going during routine 1:1 meetings. Managers are responsible for creating a safe atmosphere, where team members can openly discuss issues related to mental health, and work with the team member to a resolution.

GitLab also offers a Slack channel · [mentalhealthaware](#) · dedicated to surfacing and discussing topics related to mental health.

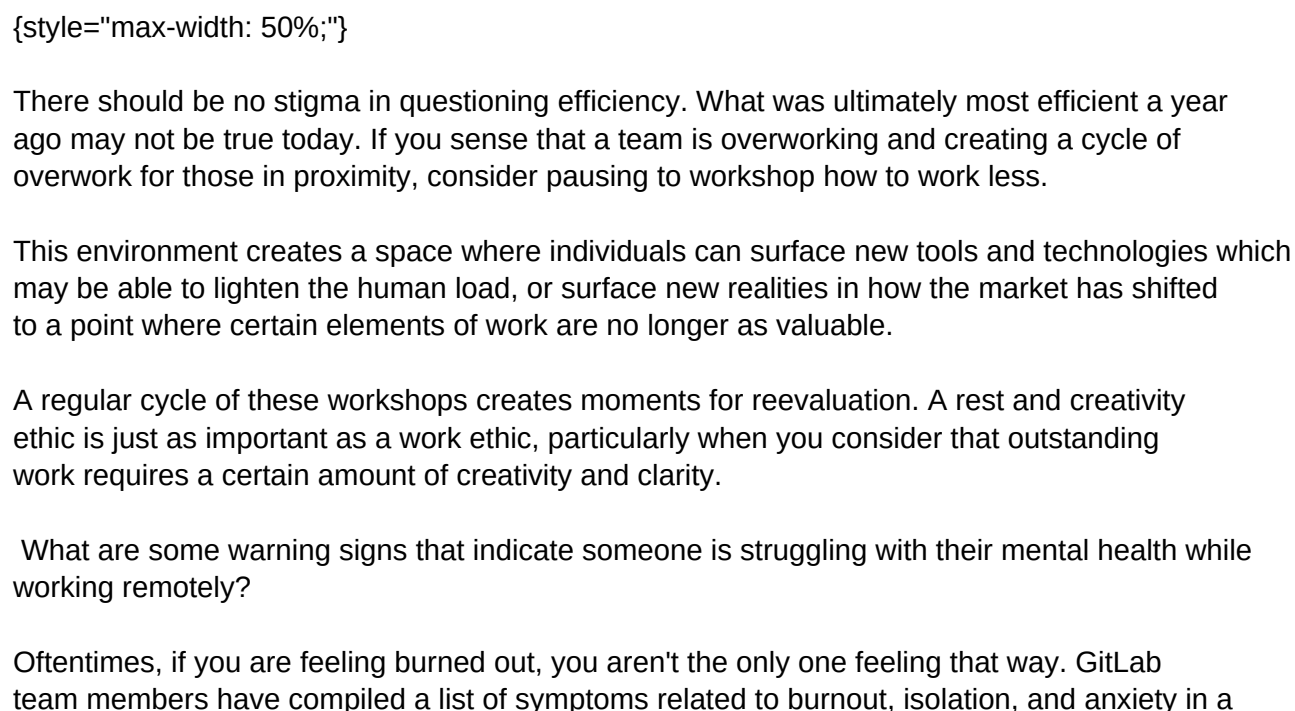
Build psychological safety

Creating a non-judgmental culture requires leaders to cultivate psychological safety within their teams. This means ensuring that team members feel safe to take healthy risks, openly admit when they make mistakes, and challenge one another in a productive, positive way.

Not only can this affect each individual team member's performance and well-being, it also has an impact on the overall environment of inclusion and belonging on your team. This is particularly important in a remote or hybrid environment, especially for a global team with varying experiences. Understanding your team members' perspectives requires a high level of empathy, communication, and intentionality.

Learn more about how to build a psychologically safe environment.

Workshop how to work less

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There should be no stigma in questioning efficiency. What was ultimately most efficient a year ago may not be true today. If you sense that a team is overworking and creating a cycle of overwork for those in proximity, consider pausing to workshop how to work less.

This environment creates a space where individuals can surface new tools and technologies which may be able to lighten the human load, or surface new realities in how the market has shifted to a point where certain elements of work are no longer as valuable.

A regular cycle of these workshops creates moments for reevaluation. A rest and creativity ethic is just as important as a work ethic, particularly when you consider that outstanding work requires a certain amount of creativity and clarity.

What are some warning signs that indicate someone is struggling with their mental health while working remotely?

Oftentimes, if you are feeling burned out, you aren't the only one feeling that way. GitLab team members have compiled a list of symptoms related to burnout, isolation, and anxiety in a

blog post. A few are highlighted below.

- 1. You're constantly tired
- 1. You no longer enjoy things
- 1. Your job performance suffers
- 1. Your physical health suffers (headaches, irregular breathing patterns, etc.)
- 1. Your relationships are strained
- 1. You feel socially zapped
- 1. You disable video for team calls to prevent others from seeing your pain
- 1. You are perpetually concerned with whether you are doing enough
- 1. You worry that your contributions are too few or too insignificant
- 1. You feel unable to choose family first

What are some ways to reduce stress when working remotely?

{{< youtube "Q9yjo6lOqX4" >}}

In the video above, Darren (Head of Remote, GitLab) and Sara (Senior Partner Marketing Manager, GitLab) discuss tips, tricks, and insights on preventing burnout and achieving balance.

Prevention is a team sport. Leaders must work to establish a workplace culture that empowers rather than restricts, managers must be proactive in sensing the signs of mental strain, and team members must feel comfortable surfacing issues while they are still manageable. Below are several recommendations for avoiding and preventing burnout, according to GitLab team members.

- 1. Set clear boundaries between work and home
- 1. Take vacation
- 1. Take a "mental health" day to lower your stress (spend time outdoors, get a massage, get some exercise)
- 1. Know when to take a break
- 1. Put a break reminder on your computer
- 1. Switch off when you're away from work
- 1. Don't suffer in silence
- 1. Don't go straight to work after you wake up
- 1. Remove Slack from your smartphone or at the very least, turn off notifications for it
- 1. Keep each other accountable. When you notice someone in a different time zone should be asleep, tell them
- 1. Use your Slack status to share a message with the team that you are unavailable
- 1. Schedule random coffee breaks
- 1. You can use informal communication mechanisms such as virtual trivia sessions, talent shows, scavenger hunts, and global pizza parties/meals to help bond as a team and prevent work-related burnout.

The power of being proactive

GitLab has added a number of changes to the company handbook, encouraging managers and team members to be proactive when it comes to recognizing and avoiding burnout, isolation, and anxiety.

- 1. Encourage team members to communicate with their manager when they recognize burnout

1. Encourage team members to notice signs of burnout in their peers and direct reports
1. Added tips to avoid burnout

Block Potential PTO in advance

It's therapeutic to set an annual reminder (near year-end works well) to block out windows for potential PTO in the year ahead. Toggle through the forward 12 months in Google Calendar and create Busy blocks entitled "Blocked for Potential PTO" during days or weeks where future-you may appreciate present-you scheduling time off. Days before and after major holidays, anniversaries, birthdays, daylight savings time (time off to savor more sunshine!), or other moments of importance are a great place to start.

Be liberal in scheduling these blocks. They are two-way doors, and can always be removed or reduced. This exercise serves as a forcing function to be proactive about scheduling time to rest and recharge before you need it. It also provides a great visual pause for others. E.g. If someone wants to schedule you for a webinar in six weeks, but notices a Potential PTO Block on your calendar, it will prompt them to ask you if you intend to convert it to a definitive PTO block. This prevents your schedule from perpetually filling up before you have a chance to formalize a break.

Make a PTO to-do list

If you find yourself anxious about missing out, or overlooking a work-related to-do list, consider replacing that to-do list with a PTO To-Do List for the duration of your paid time off. This may include items such as practice yoga, schedule coffee with a family member or friend, go for a walk/hike/cycle, sleep X hours per night, nap X hours per day, read X chapters in a new book, etc.

Take a moment for gratitude

It is easy to focus on the negatives. Many times when something goes wrong, or we make a mistake, we jump to the negative outcomes. In these moments, take a pause and ask yourself "What is good about this situation?". Focusing on the positive impact can make your day go a lot better. It is easy to forget to focus on gratitude, so if needed, help yourself with a prompt. A simple reminder in your calendar, or Post-It note at your work station with the word gratitude can remind you to focus on what you've learned or discovered in a situation rather than the negatives. You can also try asking yourself what you are grateful for each morning to start getting in the habit of focusing on the positives.

This section has been contributed by Matt Mochary.

GitLab team members are welcome to join the daily-gratitude Slack channel (and remember, there's also a :gratitude: emoji!).

Be transparent about boundaries

Whether you're communicating with a coworker or someone external to the company, it's helpful to be transparent about the boundaries you've set for your mental health, well-being, and life outside of work. This is especially impactful for managers and leaders, because it normalizes the conversation around mental health and sets an example for others on the team.

If you're invited to a sync meeting that you can contribute to asynchronously, this can be as simple as one line added to an email response. Here's an example from Darren M., GitLab's Head of Remote:

> "I'm intentionally limiting my sync sessions in 2021 to prioritize well-being and family. Thanks for understanding."

This is also something you can discuss live with your manager or team during regular 1:1 or team meetings. Sharing openly about these boundaries builds empathy, trust, and reinforces a non-judgmental culture.

Set realistic expectations

Leadership must be sensible about expectations. If a company's OKRs (objectives and key results) and KPIs (key performance indicators) are unattainable without compromising company values, this incongruence is a recipe for fostering burnout, isolation, and anxiety across a team.

It is foolish to expect a team member to maintain excellent mental health when their workload requires a sustained amount of sacrifice. There is a fine line between collaborating with a team member on an ambitious goal and assigning a task that will be perceived as impossible.

This nuance requires a leader who is adept at understanding a team member's strengths and weaknesses. What is perceived as impossible for one team member may seem trivial to another; it is not always the task that triggers duress, but mismatching a task with an ill-equipped team member.

This can be more pronounced in a remote setting. Leaders should pay close attention to blockers and struggles, and be proactive in asking about these during 1:1 sessions. Phrasing questions such as "Are there any assignments that you do not feel comfortable or equipped to handle?" is a better